After all the options were carefully weighed, the R&AW spies decided that the task should be handed to the MEA.

The Shocker

As the intelligence agency continued to run spies in the USA, the MEA hired filmmakers to make propaganda videos targeting the Sikh community abroad. The objective was to present the reality of the Khalistan movement in India; it had been hijacked by criminal gangs who were accumulating large amounts of money via donations and smuggling. They had enough to buy properties abroad and there were widespread rumours that many had sent their families away from the area of conflict.

These films were shipped to the USA in the diplomatic pouch. For broadcasting purposes on paid media networks, the government had directed external affairs officials based in Washington to convert them to BETA, which yielded high-resolution visuals and quality sound. Around a hundred thousand dollars was sanctioned from secret funds to finish the task by March 1990. Mathur and other spies waited for almost two months, but there were no BETA tapes. Queries from the R&AW headquarters went unanswered. Sometime in July that year the government was informed by the bureaucrats that all the BETA tapes they had made in Washington had become obsolete.

'No one had seen a single tape. This was the greatest mystery during our spy operation against Khalistan elements in the USA. What happened to all the money? Well, it was secret funds and perhaps the booty was equally distributed among the officers handling the propaganda operation,' Mathur speculated.